

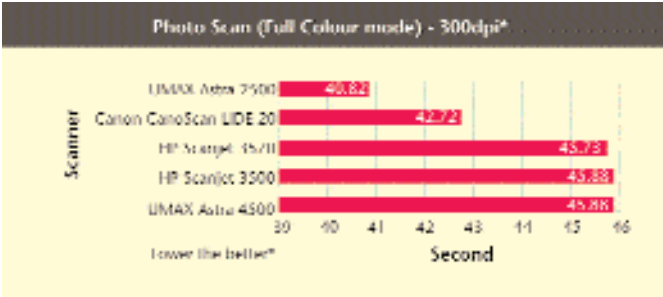
Professional user

Imaging professionals, photographers and illustrators working in the publishing and advertising industries; and those who treat photography as a serious hobby, fall within this category. Price plays second fiddle to quality here—one does not mind adding a few zeroes to the price tag, to get a scanner which can deliver outstanding quality and has a host of features. Their basic resolution requirement starts at 1200 dpi. Features such as a transparency adapter, are a must for those who deal in negatives and positives, or those who frequently dole out business presentations. A transparency adapter not only saves the money spent on a paper-print of the transparency, but also saves time. By simply scanning a transparency once, you can have the image at a desired resolution on the monitor.

Quality considerations such as the capability of a scanner to accurately reproduce colour in dark, mid and light areas, and to reproduce details play a major role in this segment. Quality was thus awarded 40 per cent, followed by speed at 30 per cent, price at 20 per cent, and warranty and support with a 10 per cent weightage.

The best scanner for professionals

The scanners which are most suited to this application area need to be loaded with accessories such as Automatic Document Feeder, Transparency Adapter and capabilities to scan at a hardware resolution of 2400 x 4800 dpi. A scanner, thus armed, has to cost more. Hence, the machines included here fell



within the price range of Rs 12,000 to Rs 25,000 and scored above 65 STTI. The scanner which managed to deliver the best performance in this segment was the HP Scanjet 4570c. This scanner costs Rs 17,999, comes bundled with Transparency Material Adapter for scanning 35 mm film as the standard accessory, and is capable of scanning at 2400 dpi and 48-bit colour depth. It was astoundingly accurate in picking different colour tones from the scanned IT8 card. The scanner managed to differentiate between all 22 grey blocks, as well as colour uniformity in the light area—one of the toughest tests to pass. This makes HP the only brand that has quality products for each and every segment.

The 4570c is also one of the fastest scanners in its class. With the capability to preview the image in just 4.5 seconds, there is hardly any warm up time taken by this scanner. While performing the test image scan at 300 dpi, we found 4570c to be the fastest again—taking just 13.97 seconds. Priced at Rs 17,999 it packs a lot of features; this model has excellent build quality with an onboard LCD panel that displays the number of copies to be scanned. HP Scanjet 3570c, 4500c, 4570c and the 5550c from HP were the only scanners in the comparison test to have the ‘Scan to CD’ hot key. This feature lets you scan a document, and then burn it on to aCD-R or CD-RW medium. The only problem with the HP scanner is the TWAIN driver which previews a document or image every time a new scan is performed. It even previews a document which was previously previewed and scanned!

At 1200 dpi however, the 4570c lost to the Canon CanoScan D1250U2F which logged 176.67 seconds to scan a photo. The Canon wasn’t far behind in the scan of the text document at 1200 dpi where it logged just 10 seconds more at 126.1 seconds, as compared to the 4570c. The strong point of the Canon is that it is more compact than the HP 44570c, and also has a Transparency Adapter built into its cover. The best feature of this machine is a hot key clearly marked as Photo, on the top of the cover to scan negatives. Apart from that it also has three hot keys for Direct Scan, E-mail and Print.

Getting in to the quality arena, which is what these scanners are made for, we found the HP Scanjet 5550c to be the best. It aced every test thrown at it. In the resolution test it managed to detect all four blocks in full colour mode, a feat which no scanner in the comparison test could match. It was 15 to 20 per cent slower in terms of speed, in spite of having a USB 2.0 interface. The 5550c comes bundled with an Automatic Document Feeder, which also acts its cover. Unlike other scanners, which have a top cover hinged at their back, the 5500c and 4500c have been clamped from their sides—the cover opens sideways. The number of buttons and their layout is the same as found on the 45xx series, but these goodies come at a cost. This scanner is priced at Rs 24,999, making it the costli-

Just Press the Right Button

Scan to Fax: This feature lets the user fax a scanned document using an inbuilt application. It needs the telephone line (not a fax machine) connected to the PC via a modem. This transmission takes place using TAPI protocol.

Scan to Print/Copy: Lets the user directly print the scanned document from a locally connected or a network printer. This saves the additional click to initialise the printer program and take the print-out. The document is also saved as an image for later use.

Scan to E-mail: Lets the user directly mail the scanned document. The moment the scan-to-mail button is pressed, the system will initialize the default email client, enter the email address of the recipient and the document will be mailed.

Scan to OCR: This is a new addition which is fast becoming common. This button, when pressed, scans the document and initializes the OCR software. The scanners which have this feature are usually bundled with older, or a 'light' version of an OCR-software.

Scan to CD: This relatively new feature scans the document and burns it directly on to a CD-R or CD-RW medium, hence saving lots of hard drive space and also imparting mobility to data.

Scan to Web: This feature scans a document, and posts it directly to a desired Web page.